A short introduction to the
multi-element model of behaviour change

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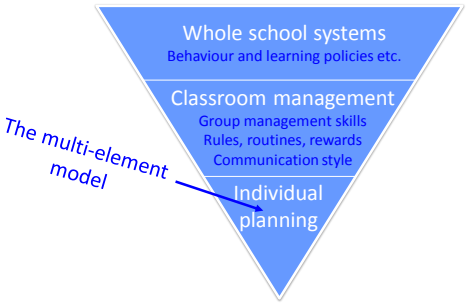
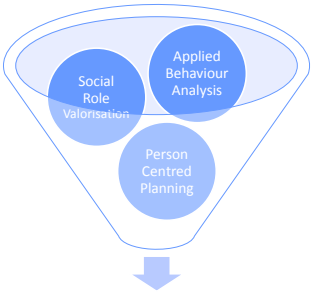
December 2016

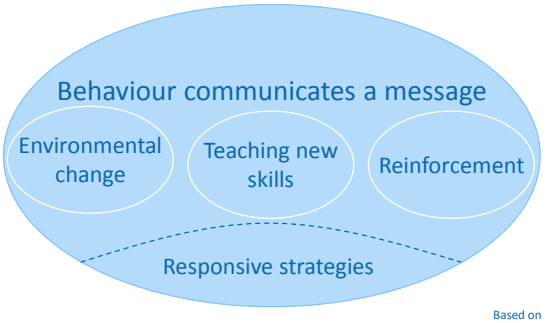
## The context



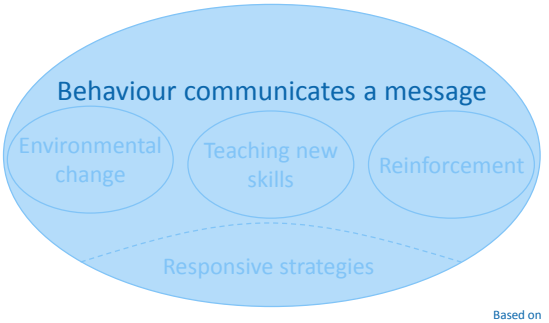

Positive Behavioural Support

## The multi-element model




Based on
LaVigna, GW & Willis, TJ (1995)

## The multi-element model

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Children are invariably trying to solve problems rather than be one!

Their solutions to problems are often misguided because their concept of the problem is faulty or because their skills leave much to be desired.

Martin Herbert (1985)
Caring for Your Children

"…when problematic behaviour occurs, rather than asking "What is wrong with you?" we...[could more usefully be]… asking "What has happened to you?"

…..Asking these questions (even silently to ourselves) can influence how we interpret, feel about and respond to a situation.

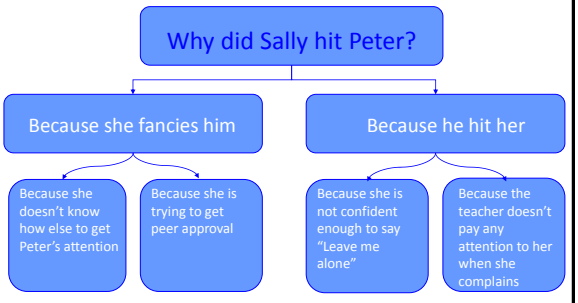
It can help to contextualize the behavior, foster compassion and connection, and highlight strengths people are bringing to bear despite the adversities they face."

Dorado, Martinez, McArthur, & Leibovitz, (2016), p. 164

## Hearing the message

What problem or task is the child trying to solve when he or she does.....

## Why-why questioning



## Some handy tips

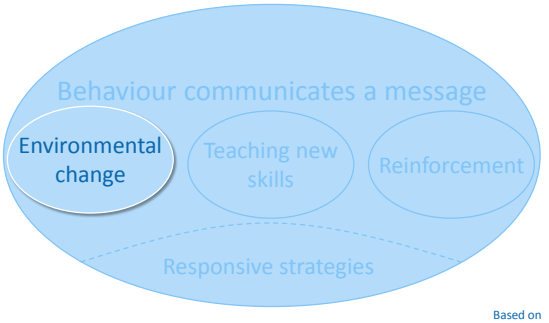
**T**est your theories

**I** want, need, wish…..

**P**resent –focused goals

**S**kills that are legitimate to teach

## The multi-element model

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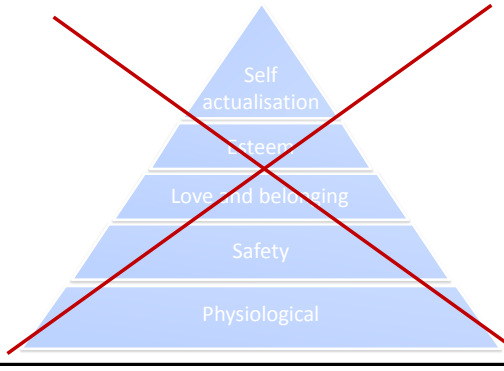
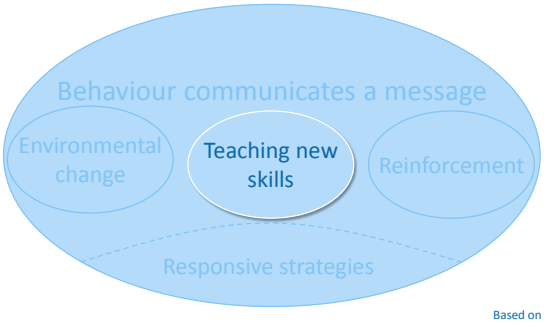
## Maslow's hierarchy of need



## Ecological context

- Physical
- Curriculum
- Personal: between and within
- Choice & structure

## The multi-element model

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## Teaching new skills

**Alternative skills**

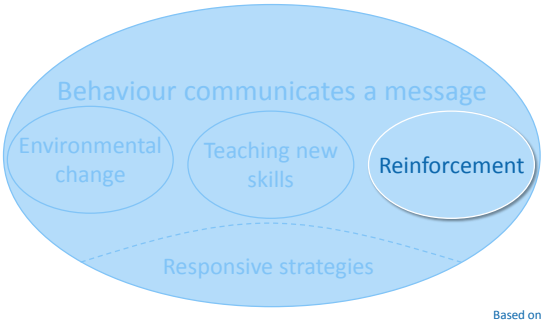
*Direct replacement*
Alternative, more appropriate ways of achieving the same goal

*Steps to target*
Skills that the child may need to be taught in order to show the new behaviour

**Coping and tolerance skills**

Ways that the child can manage if their needsare not being directly met

## The multi-element model

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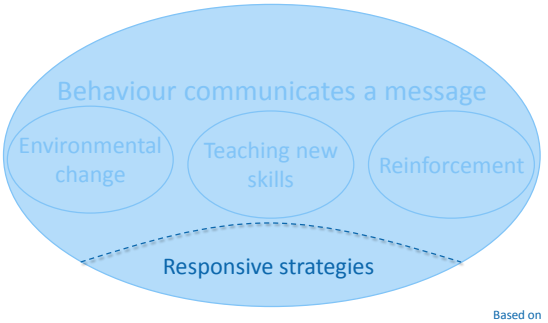
## The multi-element model

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## Matching law

"the allocation of responses to choices available on concurrent schedules of reinforcement; rates of responding across choices are distributed in proportions that match the rates of reinforcement received from each alternative"

Herrnstein, 1961

## Matching law

"Matching law focuses not on the consequences of an act itself but on the consequences of that act relative to the consequences of other acts"

Herrnstein, 1997

## Time allocation

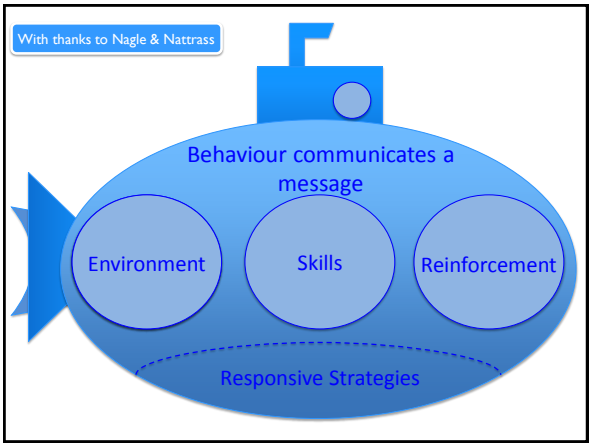
"…the guiding metaphor of the molar view is allocation….the molar view likens behavior to cutting up a pie. Choice is time allocation (Baum & Rachlin, 1969). All behavior entails choice. All behavior entails time allocation."

Baum, 2002 (p. 98-99)

## Time allocation

"Instead of thinking of reinforcement as a sort of ''moment of truth'' (e.g., Ferster & Skinner, 1957; Skinner, 1948), defined by contiguity with a momentary response, we may think of reinforcement as a cumulative effect, as selection through time (Skinner, 1981; Staddon, 1973), shaping patterns of behavior (activities) in lineages."

Baum, 2002 (p. 113)

## Counter-intuitive strategies

- High level of non-contingent reinforcement
- Diversion to a preferred event
- Strategic capitulation